A Few Conversations, One Dated Page

A plan for recording Dad's preferences at his pace: ten actions in order, with a line for who does each.

The goal: a first, dated page of Dad's routines and preferences in his own words, which he has read and corrected, and which the family knows how to keep current. It can take a month or a year.

Share the list. Put a name next to each action and tick it when it's done. The “by when” column is there if a date helps you; leave it empty if it doesn't.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Ask Dad to describe a good day. Let him tell it his way, and write down his phrases.			
2. Ask about his mornings and evenings, and note the order he likes things in.			
3. Note what he enjoys eating, what he'd rather not have, and his usual mealtimes.			
4. Start a separate list for allergies and anything a doctor has told him about food. Note where each item came from, and leave anything unsure as a question for his doctor or pharmacist.			
5. List the activities and the people he looks forward to.			
6. Ask how he likes to be addressed and spoken to.			
7. Ask what helps him when he's somewhere unfamiliar.			
8. Read the page back to Dad. Change what he wants changed, and put the date on it.			
9. Ask which few things he'd want on a short version, and who he'd be happy to have see it. Write down his answer. Nothing needs to be sent to anyone.			
10. Agree with Dad how you'll come back to it: a date, an occasion, or whenever something in his life changes.			

You're done when

There is a current page of Dad's routines and preferences that he has read and corrected, each note says whether it came from him or from someone else and carries a date, and the family knows how the page will be updated and who Dad is happy to have see it. What comes after that, a professional's review of the page and the question of when and with whom to share it, isn't on this list, because it isn't the family's to do alone.

Along the way

- Don't fill a gap by guessing. “Haven't asked yet” is a finished line.
- If Dad would rather not talk about something, write “he'd rather not say” and leave it. That is his answer for now.
- If two people remember something differently, write both and ask Dad the next time it comes up naturally.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes the family's part. It doesn't decide what Dad would want in a situation he hasn't discussed, turn anything he likes into an instruction for a caregiver, or confirm that anything on the page is medically right for him. Finishing it doesn't stand in for the professional review it prepares you for.

Ready for the next step?

You've had the conversations, and there's a dated page that Dad has read. The care interview goes on from there: it takes you through his situation area by area, with a source and a date kept beside what you tell it, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

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